

THE FRAME ANALYSIS OF PARTICIPATION

A GOFFMANIAN TAKE ON DEMOCRATIC INTERACTION AND ITS AMBIGUITIES

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INTRODUCTION

Erving Goffman's frame analysis shows its real value and relevance when used to interpret ambiguous, vague, uncertain situations in social and public life, situations whose definition is unclear to the participants or to the observer¹. These situations certainly include public meetings and other events or activities of participatory democracy. Organized just about everywhere and in different fields, often by public authorities under the auspices of institutions, these meetings generally give rise to a great deal of perplexity. Anyone who has attended one of these events will recognize that they are part of those situations where the key question of *Frame Analysis* arises: "What's going on here?". This generalized perplexity comes with rather negative assessments of these practices, both from the citizens involved and academic analysts. State-generated participatory processes are often deemed "boring", "dull", "awkward", "weird", or "phony". This skepticism towards institutional civic life (Baicocchi et al. 2017) and the "avoidance of politics" (Eliasoph 1998) it involves is then partly based on affective and aesthetic evaluations regarding the qualities of the proposed experience.

It is precisely on this point that there is still room for innovation in research on democratic interaction and that *Frame Analysis*'s learnings are proving critical. Indeed, the main theories of participatory democracy focused on communicative interaction and experience are characterized by perfectionism and tend to appreciate the democratic experience only in the major mode, as an *épure*². This is the case with Habermas as with Dewey, who both view trouble and ambiguity as provocations for deliberation or inquiry. For them, trouble is an important yet residual dimension of experience that the political collective must seek to dispel, whether through an ethic of discursive validity (sincerity, truth, rightness) and mutual criticism in Habermas, or collective inquiry in Dewey. Neither considers the possibility that democratic participation is marked by fundamental trouble (Berger 2020), structural rather than residual ambiguity (Tavory 2009; Berger & Romijn 2016). Yet a realistic, ethnographic approach leads us to believe that this bizarre, or at least flustered, vague, ambiguous character of civic participation is neither accidental nor residual but actually inherent.

There is, therefore, a clear interest and opportunity to rediscover and valorize Goffman's contributions to these issues, which requires a better understanding of frame analysis as a theory of "the organization of social experience." Indeed, while Goffman's "legacy to political sociology" seems long established (Gamson 1985), the sociology of civic participation and

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² This critique of perfectionism can be found in Luhmann's comments on Habermas (Luhmann 1971) and in Lippmann's on radical democrats - Dewey's name is never mentioned (Lippmann 1925/1993).